

Exploring History

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****World history spine**** — eras, civilizations, and load-bearing turning points.

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1. Method

- Primary vs secondary sources — provenance matters
- Periodization — convenience with argued boundaries
- Historiography — interpretation changes with evidence

2. Eras (global spine)

Era	Span (approx)	Hallmark
Prehistory	to ~3500 BCE	Stone tools, migration, agriculture dawn
Ancient	~3500 BCE–500 CE	States, writing, empires
Medieval	~500–1500	Feudalism, trade routes, plague
Early modern	~1500–1800	Print, exploration, revolution
Modern	~1800–1945	Industrial, world wars
Contemporary	1945–present	Cold War, decolonization, digital

3. Civilization anchors

- Mesopotamia — law, wheel, city
- Egypt — Nile agriculture, monuments
- Indus & China — urban planning, bureaucracy
- Greece & Rome — citizenship, law, engineering
- Islamic golden age — algebra, medicine, translation
- Americas — Maya, Aztec, Inca independently

4. Load-bearing years (examples)

Year	Event	Why it matters
1440	Gutenberg press	Mass literacy, Reformation enable
1492	Columbian exchange	Global biology & economy rewired

1789	French Revolution	Nation-state, rights discourse
1914	WWI begins	Modern industrial total war
1945	UN, atomic age	New world order
1989	Berlin Wall falls	Cold War fracture

5. AI retrieval keys

Index: `era`, `region`, `civilization`, `year`, `source\_type`. Dewey ****900****.